Anxiety is often the *result* of being neurodivergent in a world that isn't built for you, rather than a separate thing. Whether this belongs under the neurodivergent umbrella is genuinely debated. Many people who have it identify as neurodivergent; some prefer not to. Both are reasonable, and nobody gets to decide it for you.

In plain words

Anxiety disorders involve worry and physical alarm that persist beyond the situation causing them. The body's threat system runs hot and doesn't switch off. Social anxiety specifically involves intense fear of judgement — and for a lot of neurodivergent people, it's a very reasonable response to years of getting it subtly wrong in public.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Your body reacting to danger while your mind knows perfectly well there isn't any.
- Replaying a two-second interaction from four years ago at three in the morning.
- Avoiding something small, then feeling ashamed of the avoidance.
- Exhaustion — the alarm running all day takes real fuel.
- Being told to relax, which has never once worked for anybody.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"Just don't worry about it."	If that worked, nobody would have anxiety. The worry isn't chosen.
"It's all in your head."	It's substantially in your body — heart, gut, chest, muscles.
"Everyone gets nervous."	Nervous passes. This doesn't, and it makes decisions for you.
"They're being antisocial."	Social anxiety is usually wanting to be there and finding it unbearable.
"Avoiding it will help."	Avoidance shrinks the world. Gradual, supported exposure is what actually works.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Excellent risk assessment — they've thought of the thing you missed.

Deep conscientiousness and preparation.

Empathy for anyone frightened or out of their depth.

Attention to detail and consequence.

Considerable courage, since they do things afraid rather than unafraid.

What actually helps

- ☐ Give notice and detail in advance
- ☐ Don't repeatedly reassure — support instead
- ☐ Go with them the first time
- ☐ Offer an exit route and mean it
- ☐ Say what will happen, specifically
- ☐ Never say 'just relax'

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

“What would make this easier?”

“We can leave whenever.”

“Here's exactly what'll happen.”

LESS HELPFUL

“Just relax.”

“There's nothing to worry about.”

“You're overthinking it.”

The alarm is real, even when the danger isn't. Turning it down takes support, not willpower.

If you are struggling right now, you don't have to wait until it gets worse. In the UK you can call Samaritans free on 116 123, any time, or contact your GP. Elsewhere, your local crisis line or doctor is the place to start.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk